his individual psychology and personality to the extent possible from what was composed on his orders as well as from what is archaeologically knowable about the lifeways of the more ordinary people of his time. By peering over the palisades of a Mauryan city, by journeying along the roads that were used by travellers in those times, by studying the art and artefacts made and used by his people, we can imagine the world of Ashoka and understand the character and the challenges of the times in which the life of this emperor unfolded.

This book, thus, is more in the nature of a chronicle around a royal life. It deals with how Ashoka lived and how he ruled, and, above all, what he thought and how he disseminated his ideas. I salvage his persona as much as credibility permits. And my salvage operation is based as much on what he himself articulated as on what came to be preserved in the form of archaeological relics that remain of the environment which shaped his life and times.

Why another *Ashoka*?[27]

Partly because Ashoka has fascinated generations of writers and scholars. The fascination stems in some ways from the fact that we are drawn to leaders and public figures whose ideas and actions have influenced the lives of large populations. Ancient India shows several powerful rulers, but they have not captivated the minds of modern writers in the way that Ashoka has. A conquering king like Samudragupta (*c*. 350–370 CE), for instance, combined aggrandizement on a subcontinental scale with a personal predilection for music and poetry. The formidable queen of Kashmir, Didda (*c*. tenth century CE), exercised political power for close to fifty years, first behind the scenes and then overtly; in the process she overshadowed every male ruler of that region. Yet neither Samudragupta nor Didda has lured modern historians with a biographical bent.[28] This may well be because the sources are thought inadequate, a view borne out by a contrasting example, that of Harshavardhana of Thaneshwar and Kanauj